University Of Cape Coast



DEPARTMENT OF COMMUNICATION STUDIES

COMMUNICATIVE SKILLS

CMS108

GROUP 19

QUESTION:

Formal letters

I. Features
II. Uses
III. Language

FORMAL LETTERS

Objectives

At the end of this lesson, one should be able to;

Introduction

Formal letters are one of the most common form of official letters, framed and presented in almost all organizations, be it companies, schools, colleges, business firms, institutions, agencies, or any departments of corporate sectors. It is a highly professional yet effective form of communication in work places. The structure of formal letters is of a definite form and should always be followed strictly. The primary nature of formal letters is that they should be short and informative. The effectiveness of a formal letter lies in the complete presentation of the most significant issues in a clear and compact manner. Formal letter writing is undoubtedly one of the most challenging types of letter format. When putting it together, often you are addressing a person or organization with whom you are not familiar and the quality of your content, including spelling and grammar will be strongly scrutinized. In general, what you put together will have one of the following purposes:

- Make a complaint
- Request something
- Make an enquiry

Types of Formal letters

The following types of formal letters will always be provided in the correct formal letter format that you require and will be crafted to achieve the outcome that you require:

1. **Letters of complaint**: Many people feel it very necessary to write a letter of complaint regarding faulty products or poor service. A complaint letter needs to be carefully written to ensure that it is both firm but also polite so as not to alienate the reader. It also needs to make it clear what you are looking for in the way of compensation while not giving away too much about what steps you may take in the future.

2. A **covering letter** for your job application: all job applications should be accompanied with a concise and well written covering letters for CV to boost your chances of being selected for an interview. A well written cover letter should highlight the main reasons why you are the best person for the job.

3. **Thank you letter**: a letter of thanks can be hard to write often because of its likely brevity. Yet thank you letters are a great way to build good relationships in both business and personal lives.

4. **Letter of rejection**: whether you are rejecting a business proposal or a job applicant it is polite to provide proper job rejection letters. A well written letter can maintain their interest in your company and help to build your relationships and reputation.

5. **Reference letter**: reference letters can be difficult to write for a large number of reasons and many people would like to have someone do the job for them. These letters should be factual and provide the reader with precisely the information that they are looking for.

6. **Letter of recommendation**: unlike a simple reference letter a letter of recommendation is there to actually recommend the person being written about and to endorse them to the reader. Something that can be very hard to achieve without going over the top.

7. **Resignation letter**: when you are leaving a job you want to ensure that you do not burn any bridges or alienate anyone that you have worked with. After all you may want to work with them again at some point in the future and a well written letter of resignation can help you maintain good relations.

8. **Sales letter**: these letters can be very difficult to write in a manner that is not just seen as spam by the reader causing them to discard the letter without even reading it fully. This is why expert help from a good copywriter is almost always needed to write these well.

9. **Letter of introduction**: a letter of introduction is similar to a sales letter but is often used to introduce an individual, company or services with the intention of following up later with the sales talk.

10. **Letter of interest**: a letter of interest is similar to a covering letter for a job but is typically sent to companies that you are interested in working for that are not currently advertising any jobs within your area of interest. These can be highly effective if written well as they show initiative and a drive to succeed.

Features Formal Letter

A. Addresses:

1. **Writer's Address**
   The return address should be written in the top right-hand corner of the letter. That indicates the address of the person writing the letter.

2. **Recipient Address**
   The inside address should be written on the left, starting below your date. It mostly indicates the address of the receiver.

Styles of Addresses for A Letter

An address is one of the compulsory components of a letter. Regardless of what type of letter you are writing, you simply cannot write a letter without putting an address. A formal or an official letter will require that the writer supply two addresses – the sender's address and the recipient's address. The recipient is the one to whom the letter is going to whereas the sender is the one writing the letter. Regardless of what type of letter one is writing, the addresses chose can either be written in the slant method or the block/straight method.

Slant Method Address

The slant method of writing an address is very similar to an upturned triangle or pyramid. Here, the address is written in such a manner that it resembles an upside down pyramid or triangle; when the date of the address is added to it then it begins to look more like an hourglass.

Example of a slanted address is:

Obuatupam Nkatenkwam Primary School,
P.O. Box 223,
Kumasi.

As you can see from the example above, the address bore great resemblance to an upturned pyramid.

The Block/Straight line Method Address

This type of address can be used when writing both a formal and informal letter. The block address is a type of address where the writer writes the beginning of each of a line of the address in such a manner that they form a straight line.

Example of the block/straight address:

Obuatupam Nkatenkwam Primary School,
P.O. Box 223,
Kumasi.

The block style of address is mainly used when writing formal letters.

An address can also be either punctuated or unpunctuated. What is a punctuated form of address? These types of addresses simply have punctuation marks in them and at the end of each line of the address.

For example:

Obuatupam Nkatenkwam Primary School,
P.O. Box 223,
Kumasi.

What is the unpunctuated form of address? This is the opposite of the punctuated style. With this style, punctuations are not used in the address.

For example:

Obuatupam Nkatenkwam Primary School
P.O. Box 223
Kumasi.

As you can clearly see, the address above is devoid of punctuations, which is why it is the unpunctuated form.

Note: The punctuated and unpunctuated forms can be applied to the block/straight styles or the slant

B. Date:

Different people put the date on different sides of the page. You can write this on the right or the left on the line after the address you are writing to. Write the month as a word.

For example;

January 25th, 2018

25th January, 2018

25-01-2018

Note: In official it is not advisable to use this type of date writing; 25/01/2018

C. Salutation or greeting:
Salutations are your greetings meant for the recipient of the letter. They are always formal for example;

1. Dear Sir or Madam,
   If you do not know the name of the person you are writing to, use this. It is always advisable to try to find out a name.

2. Dear Mr. Jenkins,
   If you know the name, use the title (Mr., Mrs., Miss or Ms., Dr, etc.) and the surname only. If you are writing to a woman and do not know if she uses Mrs. or Miss, you can use Ms., which is for married and single women.

D. **Heading/Title**
This carries the reason you are writing the letter in one sentence, it should be in capital letters and should be underlined. It is the subject of the formal letter that is; it carries the main idea for writing the letter.

For example:

APPLICATION FOR EMPLOYMENT

PROBLEMS FACING MY COMMUNITY

Reasons Why Students Attend Lectures Late.

E. Body

The body, contains paragraph that merge to elaborate on the heading sated above in your letter. It has three main parts which are;

I. **First /introductory Paragraph:** The first paragraph of formal letters should include an introduction to the purpose of the letter. It's common to first thank someone or to introduce yourself and show the motive behind the letter.

Dear Mr. Anders,

I the under-listed person wishes to apply for the position of a manger in your reputable and well known organization which was published in the Daily Guide Newspaper, on 24th February, 2018.

II. **Main Paragraphs:**

Normally, the following paragraphs should provide the main information of the letter, and build on the main purpose in the introductory or first paragraph. Mostly formal letter has main ranging between 2-5 paragraphs.

For example

Our project is moving forward as scheduled. We'd like to develop a training program for staff at the new locations. To this end, we have decided to rent out space in the local business exhibition center. New staff will be trained by our experts in personnel for three days. In this way, we'll be able to meet demand from the first day.

III. **Final/concluding Paragraph:** The final paragraph should shortly summarize the intent of the formal letter and end with some call to action.

Note: “Thank you” is part of the concluding paragraph but, is written on the next of the concluding paragraph.

For example;

Thank you for your consideration of my suggestions. I look forward to an opportunity to discuss this matter further.

Thank You.

F. Subscription

1. Yours faithfully;
   If you do not know the name of the person, end the letter this way.

2. Yours sincerely;
   If you know the name of the person, end the letter this way.

3. Your signature and Name:
   Sign your name, then print it underneath the signature. If you think the person you are writing to might not know whether you are male or female, put you title in brackets after your name.

Uses of formal letters